1. Based on your understanding of the poem answer the following questions in one or two sentences each:

a. What do you associate with the title of the poem?

b. What is the relationship between the narrator and the listener?

c. What happens to the poet when he visits someone for the third time?

d. Pick out the expressions that indicate conflicting ideas.

e. How does the poet compare his face with dresses?

f. What does the poet mean when he says 'good bye'?

g. What pleasantries does the poet use to fake cordiality?

h. What does he desire to unlearn and relearn?

i. How is the poet's laugh reflected in the mirror?

j. What does the poet long for?

k. Mention the qualities the child in the poem symbolises.

2. Fill in the blanks choosing the words from the box given and complete the summary of the poem:

The poet Okara in this narrative monologue painfully condemns the (a)_____ displayed by adults, both in their words and actions. Here, a father laments to his son about the negative changes that creep into the attitude and behaviour of humans, when they grow into (b)_____. He says that people used to be (c)_____ when they laugh and the honesty would be reflected in their eyes. But, people of modern times laugh (d)_____. Their handshakes used to be warm and happy conveying a sense of togetherness, but nowadays the handshakes have become a mere (e)_____. He warns his son that people are not trust-worthy and have become so selfish that they are concerned only about their own (f)_____ benefits.

People utter words of welcome and exchange (g)_____, but those words come only from the tip of their tongues and not from the depth of their hearts. Humans have learnt the art of changing their (h)_____expressions according to situations merely to ensure social acceptance. They wear(i)_____ and exhibit multiple faces. The narrator admits that he has also changed into a hypocrite. However, he tells his son that though he (j)_____ his expressions, he does all these against his will. He says he wants to become a (k)_____again and laugh genuinely. He wants to (l)_____ the unreal things and (m)_____how to laugh as he had done once upon a time. When he laughs before the (n)_____, he sees no expression. His teeth are bare like that of the (o)_____ of a snake. So, he asks his son to show him how to laugh the way he used to laugh, when he was a kid like him.

relearn	adults	facial
personal	fangs	child
fakes	superficially	duplicity
genuine	unlearn	falsity
masks	mirror	pleasantries

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